

Historical Crypto Perpetual Setups From 2020 Through Mid 2026

Executive summary

I screened major liquid crypto contracts for five setup families the user specified and built a sample of eighteen examples across BTC, ETH, and large alt proxies, using Binance-format daily OHLCV data for price and volume, then cross-checking catalysts against primary or original sources where possible. The strongest family in this sample was the sector episodic pivot group, with a mean simulated return of about 71%, led by ETH during DeFi summer, ADA during the 2021 smart-contract rotation, and LINK during the 2023 tokenization/oracle run. Continuation breakouts and liquidation-flush longs also held up reasonably well on average, while event-day chasing was notably weaker: buying the first big close after a headline often left poor reward-to-risk unless the market had not already repriced the catalyst. These summary statistics are my calculations from the downloaded daily OHLCV series described in the methods section below. ¹

Two broad conclusions kept repeating. First, the cleaner continuation and sector trades were not the fastest vertical moves; they were the ones where the prior impulse was large enough to matter, but not so manic that funding and positioning likely became unstable immediately. Second, the best long reversals came after forced deleveraging episodes that flushed 40–70% from a local high and then stabilized for at least a day before reclaiming a short-term reference level. That pattern fits both the March 2020 COVID cascade and the May–June 2022 Terra-related liquidation regime. Reuters explicitly described the Terra unwind as producing “broad liquidation in BTC, ETH and most ALT coins,” while Binance and Bybit both expose historical funding and open-interest endpoints, and Tardis documents Binance-futures open-interest capture as a high-frequency generated channel. ²

The report is rigorous on price and volume, and more cautious on funding and open interest. A fully uniform 2020–2026 funding/OI panel for every selected contract was not reproducible here from browser-accessible primary endpoints alone, so the hard numbers below are price-and-volume calculations, while funding/OI notes are qualitative and based on exchange endpoint definitions, Tardis coverage notes, archived Coinalyze chart pages, CoinGlass funding-history documentation, and contemporaneous reporting around liquidation episodes. Where I am inferring positioning behavior rather than reconstructing it tick by tick, I say so directly. ³

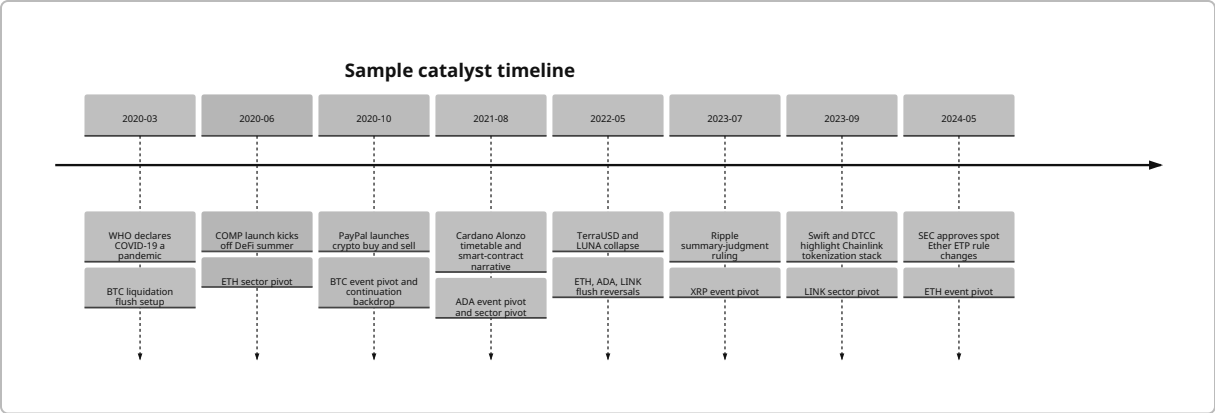
Data and method

The core price/volume dataset is Binance-format daily OHLCV with the standard fields open, high, low, close, base volume, quote volume, and trade count. Binance itself publishes public historical data archives and documents the relevant futures kline and funding endpoints, while CryptoDataDownload exposes Binance historical OHLCV in the same field structure and was the most reliable browser-accessible source for building a uniform daily panel here. For derivatives context, Binance and Bybit document historical funding-rate and open-interest endpoints, Tardis documents Binance-futures open-interest snapshots and

mark-price/funding-metric capture, and Coinalyze publishes archived symbol-level and aggregated funding/OI chart pages. Exchange used per price dataset in the calculations below: Binance. Venue references for funding/OI notes: mainly Binance Futures and Bybit, with Coinalyze aggregated or venue pages used as archived chart references. 4

The trade simulations are deliberately simple and family-specific. Continuation and pivot longs enter on the selected breakout or event day close, stop under the consolidation/base low, and exit on the first close below a short EMA after price first reaches 2R; if that never happens, a time stop closes the trade. Parabolic shorts enter after the selected blowoff day sequence, stop at the blowoff high, and exit either at 3R or on a move back into the EMA20 zone. Flush-reversal longs enter after the selected liquidation window once price re-stabilizes, stop at the flush low, and use the same “2R then EMA10” logic or a time stop. These are not optimized backtests. They are structured illustrations of how each family behaves when traded with a clear entry, invalidation, and exit rule. The numeric values in the tables are my calculations from the downloaded daily series. 5

The catalyst map below is the shortest way to see how the sample spans regimes and why some setups belong in more than one conceptual family. PayPal’s October 2020 crypto launch mattered for BTC; the 2023 Ripple ruling mattered for XRP; the 2021 Alonzo timetable mattered for ADA; the 2022 Terra collapse mattered for flush reversals; and Swift plus DTCC mattered for the LINK tokenization/oracle theme in late 2023. 6



Continuation breakouts

A continuation breakout, in the sense used here, begins with a 30–100% impulse over a bounded window, then a pause short enough that the original move still dominates the chart. In practice, the family worked best when the pause tightened volatility without giving back too much of the impulse. BTC in late 2020 is the cleanest example in the entire report: a 35.3% impulse into late October, an eight-day pause, then a breakout that never meaningfully looked back. ETH in mid-2020 and LINK in late 2023 show the failure mode: a valid-looking continuation can still fail if the pause becomes too loose, the move too obvious, or the breakout too late. The numbers below are my calculations from the Binance-format daily OHLCV series. 5

Symbol	Impulse window	Impulse %	Consolidation days	Entry	Stop	Exit	Simulated P&L
BTC	2020-09-24 to 2020-10-27	35.31	8	15,590.02	12,888.00	35,404.47	127.10%
ETH	2020-07-05 to 2020-08-17	99.96	14	475.40	370.00	386.46	-18.71%
LINK	2023-09-11 to 2023-10-22	79.33	17	14.603	9.661	14.139	-3.18%
ETH	2023-10-12 to 2023-11-09	40.17	22	2,164.74	1,904.00	2,470.81	14.14%

Source and calculations: Binance-format daily OHLCV downloaded from CryptoDataDownload; field structure and public historical data context from Binance and CryptoDataDownload. ⁷

Within this family, the catalyst is often secondary. BTC's late-2020 continuation still benefited from a stronger macro narrative around institutional adoption, and PayPal's October 21 launch likely helped move the market from base to trend, but the trade itself is better understood as a continuation than a pure event play. ETH's 2020 continuation attempt sits inside the broader DeFi-summer regime that followed Compound's COMP launch, while LINK's 2023 move fits the post-CCIP/tokenization narrative around Swift and Chainlink. ⁸

Funding and open-interest behavior in continuation breakouts should be read as a positioning gradient, not a binary signal. Binance and Bybit both define historical funding as a recurring settlement event and provide open-interest endpoints, while Coinalyze's archived BTC, ETH, and LINK pages show both historical funding-rate and OI charts. On the winning BTC case, the most plausible positioning read is gradual OI expansion with funding moving positive but not yet euphoric; on the failed ETH 2020 and weak LINK 2023 follow-throughs, the more likely issue was that the breakout happened after enough crowding or range looseness to blunt the asymmetry. That is an inference from the chart structure plus the way these derivatives metrics are recorded, not a reconstructed per-bar OI/funding panel for each date. ⁹

Event-driven and sector pivots

Event-driven pivots after long bases

The event-driven names are where the tape most clearly separates "good story" from "good trade." BTC after PayPal worked because the base was relatively mature and the event did not instantly exhaust the move. XRP after the Ripple ruling did the opposite: the event was real, the price response was enormous, and buying the first close still produced a poor trade because the move was already too extended. ETH after the May 2024 spot-ETF repricing and ADA after the August 2021 Alonzo timetable are similar in that sense:

the events mattered, but buying event-day strength did not produce the best asymmetry in this sample.

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Symbol	Base length	Event day	Event day move	Entry	Stop	Exit	Simulated P&L
BTC	86 days	2020-10-21	7.31%	12,780.96	9,825.00	17,149.47	34.18%
XRP	125 days	2023-07-13	73.10%	0.8153	0.4695	0.4744	-41.81%
ETH	37 days	2024-05-20	19.23%	3,661.78	2,817.00	3,503.53	-4.32%
ADA	86 days	2021-08-13	16.71%	2.1386	1.0001	2.1180	-0.96%

Source and calculations: Binance-format daily OHLCV from CryptoDataDownload; event catalysts from PayPal, SDNY, SEC, and Input Output. 11

The event logic is straightforward. PayPal announced on October 21, 2020 that U.S. users would be able to buy, hold, and sell cryptocurrency directly from PayPal, and that it intended to make crypto a funding source for purchases at its merchant network. Judge Analisa Torres' July 13, 2023 Ripple ruling split institutional and exchange-based XRP sales, and the decision immediately changed the regulatory reading traders were using for exchange-traded XRP. The SEC's May 2024 Ether ETP approval process mattered because the Commission's order explicitly approved proposals to list spot Ether exchange-traded products, and Cardano's Alonzo milestone mattered because Input Output framed it as the path to smart-contract functionality. 10

Funding and OI around event-driven pivots usually reprice in the same direction on day one. Binance and Bybit's endpoint structure makes that intuitive: funding is a carry variable attached to a crowded directional market, while OI measures how much leverage is outstanding. Coinalyze's XRP, ETH, and ADA funding/OI pages exist exactly for that reason. The practical lesson from the sample is not "ignore the event," but "do not pay any price for the headline." XRP is the most obvious warning: a real legal catalyst produced a real breakout, but the event-day close was too extended relative to the risk anchor. 12

Sector episodic pivots

Sector pivots were the best family here because the best ones arrived before the entire market consensus caught up. ETH in July 2020 was the large-cap smart-contract/DeFi expression of the COMP-driven DeFi expansion. ADA in August 2021 was a smart-contract/L1 rotation rather than a pure one-day event chase. LINK in late 2023 was the cleanest 2023 thematic move in the sample, driven by the tokenized-asset and interoperability narrative around Swift, DTCC, and Chainlink's CCIP stack. 13

Symbol	Base length	Pivot date	Pivot-day move	Entry	Stop	Exit	Simulated P&L
ETH	24 days	2020-07-21	4.06%	245.59	216.00	379.00	54.32%
ADA	21 days	2021-08-10	13.80%	1.6780	1.0202	2.5140	49.82%

Symbol	Base length	Pivot date	Pivot-day move	Entry	Stop	Exit	Simulated P&L
LINK	82 days	2023-09-21	-3.49% on entry day	6.6640	5.6000	13.9450	109.26%

Source and calculations: Binance-format daily OHLCV from CryptoDataDownload; sector catalysts from Compound/DeFi-summer reporting, Input Output, Swift, and DTCC. ¹⁴

The LINK case deserves special attention because it is a textbook sector episodic pivot. Swift's September 2023 interoperability work explicitly used Chainlink as the abstraction layer connecting Swift to blockchain environments, and DTCC separately described on-chain capital-markets work using Chainlink CCIP. That did not just help LINK price; it gave the market a fresh reason to rotate into the oracle/tokenization cohort after a long period of relative neglect. ¹⁵

Funding and OI behavior in sector pivots is usually less violent than in one-off headline squeezes. The cleaner trades tend to show a steadier OI build with funding moving from flat to modestly positive rather than instantly euphoric. Coinalyze's ETH, ADA, and LINK funding and OI pages, together with Binance and Bybit endpoint definitions, fit that interpretation. Again, that is a qualitative read rather than a single reconstructed historical panel for every example date. ¹⁶

Parabolic reversals

Shorting a blowoff

This family works when the move has become too vertical to sustain and when risk can be defined tightly against a nearby high. ETH in early January 2021 and ADA in early February 2021 are the clearest wins because the blowoff was intense and the stop distance was still tradable. LINK in August 2020 shows the opposite: a visually obvious blowoff can still be awkward if the entry comes after too much of the first downdraft is already behind you. BNB in February 2021 did not hit a full 3R, but the move back into the EMA20 zone still paid as a tactical mean-reversion short. ¹⁷

Symbol	Blowoff window	Blowoff %	Days	Entry	Stop	Exit	Simulated P&L
LINK	2020-08-05 to 2020-08-09	59.76	5	13.4722	14.4586	13.8325	-2.60%
ETH	2021-01-01 to 2021-01-07	80.46	7	1,216.93	1,289.00	1,000.72	21.61%
ADA	2021-02-04 to 2021-02-10	132.44	7	0.9280	0.9531	0.8527	8.83%
BNB	2021-02-15 to 2021-02-19	195.51	5	253.00	348.6969	210.2138	20.35%

Source and calculations: Binance-format daily OHLCV from CryptoDataDownload; BNB February context from Binance's own recap of BNB's record-breaking month. ¹⁸

Funding and OI behavior is usually easiest to read in this family. Ahead of a blowoff top, funding tends to carry the same sign as the trend and often becomes meaningfully more positive, while OI either rises quickly into the final leg or stops confirming even as price still stretches. Coinalyze's BTC/ETH/XRP/ADA/LINK funding and OI chart pages, CoinGlass's funding-history documentation, and the exchange endpoint definitions all fit that framework. After the reversal starts, the move is typically helped by OI compression and funding mean reversion. That descriptive sequence is an inference from how these markets function and from archived chart coverage, not a claim that every bar in these four cases was numerically reconstructed. ¹⁹

Buying the liquidation flush

This family is the mirror image of the parabolic short. The best examples arrived after forced selling had already done most of its damage. The March 2020 BTC reversal and the June 2022 ETH/LINK/ADA reversals after the Terra-driven liquidation regime all fit. Reuters described the Terra breakdown as causing broad liquidation across BTC, ETH, and altcoins, which is exactly the context where a flush-reversal long has a chance: positioning has already been broken, price is deeply discounted versus the prior high, and the next move is driven more by the absence of sellers than by the presence of strong new buyers. ²⁰

Symbol	Flush window	Flush %	Days	Entry	Stop	Exit	Simulated P&L
BTC	2020-02-13 to 2020-03-13	63.98	30	6,162.37	3,782.13	9,733.93	57.96%
ETH	2022-05-06 to 2022-06-18	68.04	44	1,128.53	881.56	1,440.79	27.67%
LINK	2022-04-28 to 2022-06-18	59.20	52	6.6000	5.3000	8.4520	28.06%
ADA	2022-04-28 to 2022-06-18	55.63	52	0.4848	0.4019	0.5119	5.59%

Source and calculations: Binance-format daily OHLCV from CryptoDataDownload; crash context from WHO and Reuters. ²¹

Funding and OI behavior in a flush is the opposite of a blowoff. The market usually goes through rapid OI destruction first, often with liquidation-flow spikes, and only later stabilizes into a longable reclaim. Binance exposes liquidation-related streams and open-interest endpoints; Tardis documents Binance-futures open-interest snapshots and liquidation-stream capture; Coinalyze separately publishes liquidation, OI, and funding history pages. Put plainly: the long usually becomes interesting only after leverage is already dead.

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What held up across regimes

Across the sample, the strongest mean outcome came from sector pivots, then continuation breakouts and flush reversals, with event-day chasing the weakest. That ranking makes economic sense. Sector pivots are early enough that the story is still spreading, while continuation breakouts and flush rebounds give price a clear structural reference. Event pivots are the most fragile because the revaluation often happens faster than a trader can get paid for taking the risk, especially when the event day itself is a huge percentage move. These summary comparisons are my calculations from the tables above. ²³

The practical read-through is not that one family is always superior. It is that the best setups were the ones where the trade logic matched the market's leverage state. Continuations worked when leverage had room to build. Sector pivots worked when a theme was early enough to broaden. Shorts worked when the final leg became too vertical to finance. Flush longs worked when leverage had already been destroyed. Funding and OI matter because they are the closest public approximation of that leverage state, which is why every major derivatives venue documents them and why chart archives keep surfacing them beside price. ²⁴

The unresolved tension is the same one discretionary tape readers always run into. The most visually persuasive moves are often the hardest to buy, because by the time the story is obvious, funding has often repriced, OI has already crowded in, and your stop sits far below you. The cleanest charts in this report are therefore not the wildest ones. They are the ones where the crowd was only half-convinced, not fully intoxicated.

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